

Spreading Your Voice

The Here's How Guide to Podcasting

Some years ago my aunt and uncle and their far-flung children communicated with each other not by writing letters, but by mailing each other audio cassette tapes of their news. Their family tape exchange was, in many ways, an analog precursor of podcasting.

Podcasting is a method of distributing audio or video content via the Web; and podcasts are frequently attached to blogs. Although the term encompasses both audio and video, podcasting has come to mean, predominantly, audio content, with videocasting or Vcasting becoming the preferred terms for video broadcasting. Podcasts have become so associated with audio files that Apple Computer's *iTunes* software calls podcasts "Internet radio."

The term "podcasting" is a contraction of iPod + broadcasting, but the term is misleading. You don't need an iPod to listen to podcasts. Any computer or MP3 player will do.

As with blogs, podcast sites range from populist to commercial. A podcast from the Vancouver region called "How to Do Stuff" (www.todmaffin.com/blogs/howtodostuff) is described as "extraordinary wisdom from ordinary people." The podcaster, Tod Maffin, a radio broadcaster and futurist, podcasts interviews of friends and neighbours on topics as varied as "how to plant a tree," "how to interview someone," "how to make great beer at home" and "how to chop onions without crying."

"Two Boobs and a Baby" (www.twoboobsandababy.com) is a podcast from Toronto residents Heather and David Delaney on having a new baby, Sam, and their new role as parents. They refer to themselves as boobs who are learning the ropes as they recount their experiences and what they've learned. Their folksy podcasts have an estimated 15,000 regular listeners.

"We started the podcast as a way to share our stories with our friends and family," says David Delaney. "But as I listened to podcasts, I realized there is a huge audience for this. We thought that on top of creating an audio-diary of stories for our children and grandchildren to hear, we could also help other first-time parents along the way. To ensure we constantly have fresh material, we are pregnant once again — due in October!"



How To Do Stuff .org
Extraordinary Wisdom. From ordinary people.

Horizontal: Michelle
Visit michelle.ca for her, and all
information and events!
Add to favourites

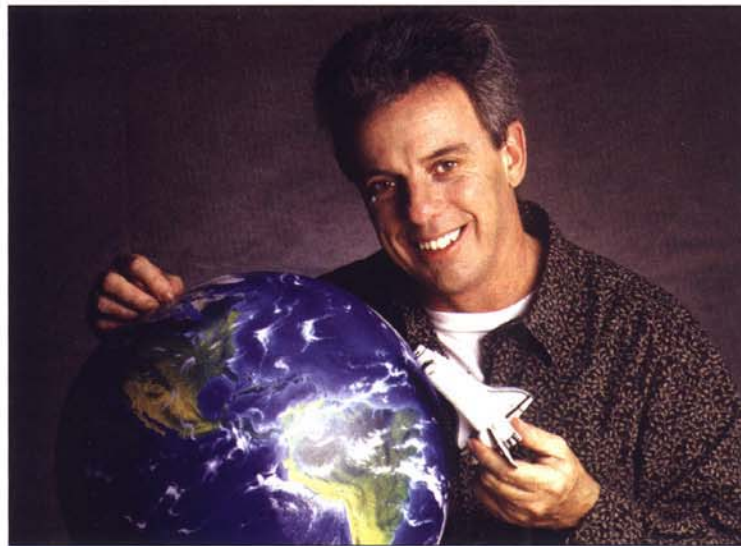
More Than a Rise
A revolutionary new way to publish your
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VISIT MY NEW PODCAST!
April 4th, 2006

todbits.com
Podcasting: Radio: Podcasting, not
Video: Stop! Read: To look up my stuff.
RSS
iTunes (one-click subscription)
Posted in Uncategorized | No Comments »

How to Fold a T-Shirt
January 27th, 2006
I didn't do this, but it's a pretty cool (albeit in
Japanese) video of how to fold a t-shirt in two easy
places.
Posted in Home | 8 Comments »

Vancouver broadcaster Tod Maffin produces a podcast called "How to Do Stuff," with interviews on subjects like folding T-shirts and chopping onions without crying.



CBC Radio has podcasts of several popular shows, including the science series *Quirks & Quarks*.

One particularly charming podcast is "Nodcasts: Small Stories" (www.rabble.ca/rpn/nod) in which the hostess, Michelle, reads bedtime stories aloud for "kids of all ages."

TV and radio stations use podcasts to allow listeners to hear past programs. CBC Radio offers podcasts of shows like *Quirks and Quarks*, *CBC Radio 3*, and *Metro Morning* (www.cbc.ca/podcasting). TVOntario's popular *Studio 2* broadcasts can be heard as audio podcasts on the TVO site (www.tvo.org).

The best way to find interesting podcasts is through a podcast directory, such as the Podcast.net directory (www.podcast.net) or from the iTunes Music Store, that lists free podcasts you can subscribe to. The free *iTunes* software is available from Apple (www.apple.com) and works on Macs and Windows computers.

Why Podcast?

Ottawa resident and word-lover Charles Hodgson maintains a podcasting site called "Podictionary: The Podcast for Word Lovers" (www.podictionary.com). It features a word a day discussing "the unexpected history of words you thought you already knew." His podcasts supplement his forthcoming book, *Carnal Knowledge: a Navel Gazer's Dictionary of Anatomy, Etymology, and Trivia*, due out in November 2006.

Asked why he took up podcasting, Hodgson replies, "I'm an author and it's hard for authors to find an audience sometimes. So when I bought iPods for my kids to congratulate them for doing well in school, it got me thinking, this might be a good way to let potential readers get to know me before my book comes out. Of course I enjoy doing the podcast just as much as I enjoy writing for a book format, so it isn't hard to keep it going. Now I am also getting good feedback from listeners that is also encouraging me onward. I chose podcasting over blogging because podcasting was newer and also more personal."

Asked about podcasting technology, Hodgson says, "I didn't find podcasting technically difficult. I went to bed on a Thursday night thinking, 'this might be a good idea,' and woke up early the next morning and set to work researching what I needed to do. By dinner on Friday I was a podcaster. I since have gotten more sophisticated recording gear (microphone mostly), but the basics are pretty easy to figure out."



Heather and David Delaney of Toronto have a podcast on having a new baby, Sam, and their new role as parents: "We thought that on top of creating an audio-diary of stories for our children and grandchildren, we could also help other first-time parents along the way."

How to Become a Podcaster

Although not yet as prevalent as text and photo blogs, podcasts are on the rise, and you can become a podcaster fairly easily. Because MP3s are a standard format for audio listening, anyone with a \$10 microphone and a computer can record audio sessions and convert them to MP3 files.

MP3s can easily be attached to blog entries and blogging services that provide RSS or Atom feeds, allowing listeners to subscribe to your material.

To promote your podcasts, register with a podcast directory such as Podcast.net (www.podcast.net). If your content is interesting, you will build a listener base and get noticed.

Hodgson gives this advice to potential podcasters: "Starting a podcast is easy. Keeping it up can be hard. You need to have something to say, and it takes a fair amount of time to prepare, record and process your podcast every time. Look for a subject that you love to talk about and preferably one for which there aren't 400 podcasts already in place. Then be consistent. If you want to do one a week, keep doing one a week."

If you're particularly handy with video equipment, you might want to start a video podcast. One of the reasons audio podcasts are more popular is that they're easier to create. An audio podcaster doesn't have to be pretty or be a good actor. Video productions are more demanding and the equipment costs more. You need a video input card, or digital video camera, and tools for encoding to video. There's no standard video format like MP3 for audio files. DivX/XviD encoding is popular, but requires extra software for viewing. QuickTime, Real and Windows Media video encoders all require proprietary viewers.

Subscribing to Podcasts

As with blogs, with an RSS reader such as Sage, you can subscribe to podcasts and be notified when new material has been published. You can also subscribe to podcasts with iTunes and play them on your computer. If you own an iPod, it will automatically download new podcasts when you sync it with your computer. With a Windows computer, you can save podcasts on your hard disk and manually transfer them to an MP3 player.

The combination of podcasts and a portable MP3 player allows listeners to enjoy broadcasts when they want, where they want. The latest MP3-capable cell phones are also a natural for this medium. Podcasts can add a new dimension to commuting. In addition to listening to talking books, you can now listen to talking blogs. ♦

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Sharing Your Pictures

Publishing photos on the Web

Pictures are for sharing. Birthdays, Christmas, the kids, vacation trips, parties, graduations: we love to share photos of these events with family and friends. Digital photos make this easier than ever. Take a neat shot with your digital or cell-phone camera, attach it to an e-mail, and you have "instant sharing."

For sharing just a few photos with a few people, e-mail works fine. But if you take lots of pictures and don't want to clobber someone's inbox with too many photo attachments, Internet photo-sharing sites offer advantages.

There are two kinds of photo-sharing sites. One type is the vendor-sponsored site, available from online photofinishers. On these sites you upload your digital images on a temporary basis so you can order prints. Your images are turned into a Website browsing gallery; you can send the link to family and friends for viewing. They can order prints of your images, or download them. Most sites allow you to put password protection on your gallery so that only authorized viewers can access it.

The other type of site is the subscription-based permanent photo-gallery site that offers large amounts of image storage (from 300 MB to unlimited) and sophisticated tools for uploading images and organizing them into folders and galleries. Costing \$30 to \$40 a year, these are the sites favoured by serious photographers.